

The KRA Filing Checklist

Every filing a Kenyan SME needs to make, month by month. Never miss a deadline or pay a penalty you could have avoided.

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Once: get registered properly

- ☐ **KRA PIN for the business**
A limited company needs its own PIN, separate from the directors' personal PINs. Sole proprietors trade under their personal PIN. Apply on iTax.
- ☐ **Correct tax obligations on your PIN**
Check which obligations are active on iTax: Income Tax, VAT, PAYE, Turnover Tax. Wrong registrations create phantom filing duties and penalties.
- ☐ **eTIMS onboarding**
All businesses must issue electronic tax invoices through eTIMS. Without it, your customers cannot claim their expenses, and large buyers will stop ordering.
- ☐ **NSSF and SHIF employer registration**
Required as soon as you hire your first employee, even casual staff on contracts.

Monthly: the recurring deadlines

- ☐ **PAYE: by the 9th of the following month**
Deduct from every employee's pay and remit on iTax. Late filing attracts a penalty of 25% of the tax due or KES 10,000, whichever is higher.
- ☐ **VAT: by the 20th of the following month**
Only if VAT-registered (mandatory above KES 5M annual turnover). File even when you owe nothing: a nil return avoids the KES 10,000 monthly penalty.
- ☐ **Turnover Tax: by the 20th of the following month**
For businesses with turnover between KES 1M and KES 25M that are not VAT-registered. Currently 3% of gross monthly sales.
- ☐ **NSSF and SHIF contributions: by the 9th**
Remit both employee deductions and the employer share. Arrears compound quickly and block compliance certificates.

Quarterly and annual

- ☐ **Instalment tax: 20th of the 4th, 6th, 9th and 12th month**
Companies expecting to owe more than KES 40,000 in annual income tax pay in four instalments (25% each). Base it on the lower of last year's tax or the current estimate.
- ☐ **Annual income tax return: within 6 months of year end**
For companies with a December year end, the deadline is 30 June. Individuals and sole proprietors file by 30 June for the prior calendar year.
- ☐ **Withholding tax: by the 20th of the following month**
If you pay rent to a non-resident, professional fees, or dividends, you may be required to withhold and remit. Check the current schedule of rates on the KRA site.
- ☐ **Tax Compliance Certificate renewal**
Valid for 12 months. Banks, tenders, and county licences ask for it. Apply on iTax once your filings are current; it is issued within days when there are no arrears.

The five mistakes we see most often

1. Registering for VAT too early, then drowning in nil returns and penalties.
2. Mixing personal and business money, which makes every filing a reconstruction project.
3. Ignoring nil returns. A return with nothing to pay still has to be filed.
4. Forgetting eTIMS, which quietly disqualifies you from supplying serious buyers.
5. Waiting for a compliance certificate emergency before clearing arrears, when a payment plan agreed with KRA earlier would have cost far less.

Where does your business actually stand?

Tax compliance is one of six pillars in our free Business Growth Check-Up. Ten minutes, no credit card, and you get a written recommendation on what to fix first.

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